Around the World in Eighty Days

A simplified retelling

Original story by Jules Verne

The same journey. Clearer, shorter English.

Abridged and retold for Speak Boldly Intermediate reading practice

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1. A very precise gentleman

Phileas Fogg lived in London according to an exact routine. He went to the Reform Club, played cards and returned home at predictable times. His new servant, Jean Passepartout, hoped that working for such a calm gentleman would finally give him a peaceful life.

On Passepartout’s first day, Fogg’s friends discussed whether improved transport made it possible to travel around the world in eighty days. Fogg believed it did. His companions doubted that a timetable could survive delays and accidents.

He wagered twenty thousand pounds that he could return to the club within the stated time. Then he went home and told Passepartout to prepare for an immediate departure.

Within hours, the man who wanted peace was travelling towards the English Channel. Fogg carried money and a schedule. Passepartout carried a mixture of excitement and alarm.

Their route would take them east through the Suez Canal, India, Asia, the Pacific and America before they

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returned across the Atlantic.

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2. An interested detective

A detective named Fix was watching travellers at Suez. A large amount of money had been stolen from the Bank of England, and Fogg seemed to fit the description of the suspected thief.

Fix mistook Fogg’s unusual journey and ready supply of cash for evidence that he was escaping. He followed him, hoping an arrest warrant would arrive while they were still on territory where he could use it.

Passepartout did not know this. He talked freely about his employer and the wager, unintentionally strengthening Fix’s suspicions.

The journey continued through Bombay. Passepartout caused trouble by entering a temple without removing his shoes, but the greater obstacle lay ahead. A railway advertised as complete still had an unfinished section.

Fogg bought an elephant and hired a guide. He had not expected the gap, but he treated solving it as part of the journey rather than a reason to abandon the plan.

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3. A rescue that changes the journey

During the journey through India, the travellers learned that a young widow, Aouda, was to be killed in a funeral ceremony. Their guide explained that she was being forced into it.

Fogg decided to help her, although the attempt could cost precious time. During the rescue, Passepartout used a disguise and quick thinking to carry her away before the crowd understood what was happening.

Aouda joined them. Fogg planned to leave her safely with a relative in Hong Kong, where she could begin a different life.

In Calcutta, the trouble from the temple caught up with them, but Fogg paid the required money and continued. Fix remained close, still convinced that a criminal was spending stolen funds.

Passepartout admired his master’s generosity, though Fogg rarely explained his feelings. The timetable mattered to him, but it had not mattered more than a person’s life.

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4. Separated in Hong Kong

In Hong Kong, Aouda discovered that her relative had moved away. Fogg invited her to continue with them rather than leaving her alone.

Fix, anxious about losing his chance to arrest Fogg, told Passepartout his suspicions. Passepartout refused to help him. Fix then left him unable to warn his master about a changed departure time, and the travellers were separated.

Passepartout reached Yokohama on the intended ship, while Fogg and Aouda had to find another route. In Japan, the servant had little money and no idea whether he would see them again. He briefly joined a travelling performance to earn his passage.

Fogg found him, and the group was reunited before crossing the Pacific. Passepartout learned that loyalty could involve more than staying beside someone. It also involved deciding what to believe when another person offered a convincing accusation.

Fix continued the pursuit. Once Fogg left British territory, the detective’s immediate interest changed: he now

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wanted him to reach England, where an arrest would be possible.

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5. Across America

In San Francisco, they boarded a train across the continent. The journey brought delays, a dangerous crossing and an attack in which Passepartout was carried away while helping protect the train.

Fogg refused to leave him behind. With soldiers, he went to recover him. The rescue succeeded, but the travellers missed their train connection.

They crossed the snow in a wind-driven sledge, then continued by rail. Every unusual solution used more money and reduced the margin for another mistake.

By the time they reached New York, their planned ship had gone. Fogg found another vessel, the Henrietta, and negotiated a passage across the Atlantic. When its available fuel ran low, he bought the ship and used parts of its wooden structure to keep the engines going.

Passepartout could scarcely believe the lengths to which the wager had taken them. Aouda watched Fogg’s determination with growing affection. His outward calm no longer seemed like an absence of feeling.

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6. The arrest

They reached Liverpool with a possible route to London still available. Then Fix arrested Fogg.

The detective had waited for this moment throughout the journey. But he soon learned that the real bank robber had already been caught. His confident pursuit had been built on a mistake.

Fogg was released. He took an express train, but arrived in London believing he had missed the deadline by a few minutes. The wager appeared lost.

At home, he faced the apparent loss of much of his fortune. Aouda asked whether there was room in his life for her. She loved him and wanted to marry him, not merely thank him for saving her.

Fogg’s answer revealed what the journey had given him even if the wager was gone. He loved her too. Passepartout was sent to arrange the marriage with a clergyman.

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7. An extra day

The arrangement uncovered a remarkable mistake. Passepartout discovered that it was Saturday, not Sunday as they believed.

By travelling east all the way around the world, they had gained a calendar day. Their own count of sunrises and days of travel had not matched the date in London.

There was still time.

Passepartout rushed back. Fogg reached the Reform Club just before the deadline and won the wager. His friends could hardly believe his appearance at the door.

The trip had cost nearly as much as he won, so it had not made him greatly richer. But money was not the full result. He had found love, trusted companions and experiences no careful routine could have supplied.

Passepartout had not obtained the peaceful employment he expected. Instead, he had helped his employer discover a life in which arriving somewhere meant more than reaching it on time.

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Words to keep

Wager — an agreement to risk money on the result of something. Fogg made a wager with his friends.

Timetable — a schedule of transport arrivals and departures. The journey depended on timetables.

Warrant — an official document allowing an arrest. Fix waited for a warrant.

Accusation — a claim that someone has done something wrong. Fix’s accusation was mistaken.

Margin — extra time or space available before a limit. Delays reduced Fogg’s margin.

Deadline — the latest time something can be completed. Fogg reached the club before the deadline.

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A question to carry with you

Which decision shows Fogg’s character most clearly: keeping his schedule, or interrupting it to help someone?

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